Between Frameworks and Practices:
Situated Knowledge and the Formalisation of Sustainability in Copenhagen Art Institutions

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Main field of study: Leadership and Organisation

Degree - Master of Arts (120 ECTS) with a Major in Leadership and Organisation.

Master Thesis - Focus Focus on Leadership and Organisation:

Societal Challenges and Organisational changes (OL675E), 30 ECTS

Spring 2026

Supervisor: Jens Rennstam

Date of Submission: 21.08.2026



MALMÖ UNIVERSITY

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I would sincerely like to thank my supervisor Jens Rennstam for insightful and challenging guidance during this process. I would similarly sincerely like to thank all of the participants who took the time to speak with me and generously shared their experiences, perspectives, and knowledge. This contribution has been essential for this study.

ABSTRACT

This study investigates how contemporary art institutions in Copenhagen understand and enact sustainability in relation to emerging sustainability demands and art-specific sustainability frameworks. As an overarching lens, this study uses Bornemark's (2020) perspective on situated knowledge to examine how questions of judgment, agency, and responsibility are acted out in relation to the emerging sustainability demands. Bornemark's perspective is considered alongside New Public Management theory, informed by Hood's conceptualisation (1995).

The empirical material is gathered using qualitative data collection from three art-specific sustainability frameworks and seven semi-structured interviews, with one representative from each institution. The study is informed by a case study design and the participants were selected using purposive sampling. The data was furthermore analysed using a thematic analysis, allowing a nuanced perspective on how sustainability is understood and conceptualised.

The findings suggest that sustainability has become an integrated part of practice, but methodology and depth of integration vary significantly between institutions. While larger institutions articulate sustainability as an organisational objective, the medium-sized and smaller institutions use informal arrangements and situated knowledge to engage with sustainability. The study also highlights how funding structures play a key role in shaping meaning and practices around sustainability. While resource constraints often result in a lack of organisation and planning for sustainability, too large of a budget can also lead to resource-intensive exhibition productions.

This study contributes to a development of the topic of sustainability in contemporary art by focusing on the role of formalised sustainability frameworks. With the use of Bornemark's (2020) perspective on situated judgment, this study highlights the importance of knowledge developed through experience and professional practice in the construction around sustainability. It suggests a deeper engagement with sustainability may require a greater recognition of situated knowledge and an openness to questioning established and formalised ways of organising, producing, and mediating art.

Keywords: Sustainability, Sustainability Frameworks, Formalised Knowledge, Situated Knowledge, Jonna Bornemark, New Public Management, Contemporary Art, Contemporary Art Institutions

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ABRIVATIONS

Abbreviation	Full term
GAOM	The Green Academy of Museums
HCU	Håndbog til cirkulære udstillingspraksisser
GCC	Gallery Climate Coalition
NPM	New Public Management
CIMAM	The International Committee for Museums and Collections of Modern Art

Chapter 1. INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background of Study

I have worked as a practicing artist, exhibition organiser, technician, and project leader within the arts in Copenhagen for approximately two decades. During this time, I have seen a significant shift in how art institutions engage and relate to the topic of sustainability. What was once a marginal or individual concern has increasingly become an institutional priority, which is reflected in organisational strategies, operational practices, and curatorial approaches. Most art institutions describes themselves as political and environmentally responsible actors, positioning their practices in relation to broader societal demands for sustainability.

One concrete shift is the institutional approaches to material use and waste. Exhibition materials were previously discarded after use, but today, many art institutions are implementing practices of reuse, recycling, and redistribution. However, these practices have not emerged uniformly or systematically. Previously, they were often driven by individual initiatives - often by the technical staff - and primarily motivated by economic constraints rather than environmental concerns. The capacity to reuse materials depends on institutional infrastructures, such as storage facilities, workshop access, and building design. These material conditions reveal that sustainability is not only an ethical ambition but also an organisational and spatial challenge.

Although sustainability has only recently been incorporated and prioritised within the art institutions, artistic practices have explored and elaborated on ecological concerns since the late 60's. Artists associated with Land Art, Earth Art and later Ecological Art began to challenge the dominant relationships between art, landscape, industrial development, and environmental degradation by focusing on the preservation and revitalisation of earth's ecosystems, often involving restoration and activism. A seminal work, produced by Agnes Denes', is 'Wheatfield - A Confrontation: Battery Park Landfill, Downtown Manhattan', from 1982. The work was a public commission, in which she grew and harvested a two-acre crop of wheat adjacent to the World Trade Centre. Denes describes the work; *"Planting and harvesting a field of wheat on land worth $4.5 billion created a powerful paradox. Wheatfield was a symbol, a universal concept; it represented food, energy, commerce, world trade, and economics. It referred to mismanagement, waste, world hunger and ecological concerns. It called attention to our misplaced priorities"* (Denes, 1982).

Critical theorists of the time were also addressing and discussing these issues. Debord wrote the essay 'A Sick Planet' in 1971, arguing that the ecological crises were not simply environmental problems, but contradictions of a capitalist logic; "*In its state-run and regulated form, the 'fight against pollution' is bound, at first, to mean no more than new specialisations, ministries, jobs for the boys and promotions within the bureaucracy'"* (Debord, 1971/2008).

1.2 Problematisation

The climate crisis has intensified expectations across several sectors, including the cultural field (Janes, 2010: Kagan; 2015 Demos; 2016Willming, 2025). Art institutions are therefore to a greater extent encouraged to respond through organisational change, which entails change of procedures, public visibility and measurable outcomes (Dominues et al, 2023). This added responsibility, has led to an emergence of art-specific sustainability frameworks, providing guidelines, tools and reporting systems to help get started with, or maintaining sustainability work. The emergence of the sustainability frameworks can also be seen in relation to the rise of NPM within culture and art in Scandinavia (Engqvist et al., 2018) Some art institutions are affiliated with the more general sustainability frameworks, such as the IPCC assessments, the Paris Agreement, and the UN's Agenda 2030. Others are affiliated with frameworks specifically fitting the arts sector, such as the international framework Gallery Climate Coalition and the Danish, Green Attraction. At the same time, some institutions are not part of any frameworks.

The majority of these frameworks focus on on measurable outcomes, such as carbon footprints, which places sustainability as something that can be structurally controlled and managed, while giving very little attention to social, ethical, and political dimensions of sustainability (Demos, 2016). Today, most of the larger and medium sized art institutions in Copenhagen are part of a framework, meaning that sustainability becomes part of organisational structure, influencing the daily operations, exhibition production and curatorial decisions. The frameworks are actively part of shaping the definition of sustainability within this specific context, and can therefore not be seen as simply neutral tools.

Despite the growing presence of sustainability frameworks, sustainability itself remains an ambiguous and slightly broad concept. The three pillars of sustainability, including the environmental, social and economic, function differently amongst the institutions. This study, rather

than assuming that sustainability has a fixed meaning, views it as something that is constructed, negotiated, and translated into different organisational practices.

Simultaneously, with heightened expectations of environmental engagement, art institutions have been publicly criticised for their funding relationships with the fossil fuel industry (Demos, 2016; Willming, 2025). The six-year Liberate Tate campaign challenged BP's sponsorship of Tate Modern, arguing that such partnerships undermined the institution's credibility (Khomami, 2016). Similar concerns have been raised in relation to the Science Museum in London, where Shell's sponsorship of a climate exhibition prompted criticism over the museum's independence and the influence of corporate sponsorship on the communication of climate issues (Bakare, 2021). In December 2024, members of the Danish climate activist group Nødbremsen, which is part of the international climate activist network A22, threw orange paint on a painting at Statens Museum for Kunst, in Copenhagen. The museum disapproved of the action while stating its commitment to the green transition. The activists explained that the aim was to draw attention to the urgency of the climate crisis. The participants are now facing criminal charges (Skjoldager, 2024). These examples highlights how sustainability, further more, is connected to public legitimacy. This positions art institutions in a complex way, as they are increasingly questioned by activists, artists and audience, resulting in a damaged public image, which in turn can effect funding and policy changes.

As sustainability is becoming more ingrained in institutional practices, one question is how it affects artistic production and on what terms art becomes valued. This raises further questions about how these organisational changes are negated with artistic autonomy, experimentation and freedom of expression.

While sustainability has become a central concern within contemporary art institutions, less is known about how these organisational changes are understood and negotiated by the institutions themselves. The study therefore, investigates how contemporary art institutions conceptualise sustainability and how these understandings shape organisational practices, artistic production, and artistic value.

1.3 Empirical Focus

This study is situated in Copenhagen, Denmark, a country which has positioned itself internationally as an sustainability forerunner, known for its ambitious environmental plans,

exemplified by the goal of becoming carbon-neutral. CopenPay recently introduced by the Copenhagen tourist board, aims to encourage tourists, through a badge and reward system, to act in an environmentally sustainable way while on holiday. Many of the rewards include visits for free or at a reduced price at the city's museums and art institutions (CopenPay, n.d.), this in turn means that the selected institutions needs to comply with CopenPay's regulations and also becoming a symbol of the city's progressive sustainability politics. This puts role and missions of the art institutions in a new position, which this study investigates.

Against this backdrop, this thesis investigates how Copenhagen-based art institutions understand and enact the concept of sustainability. This thesis uses and understands sustainability according to the three pillars of sustainability; social, and economic considerations.

The empirical material consists of interviews and policy documents from seven contemporary art institutions, and documents from three sustainability frameworks. While the institutions differ in size, organisational structure, economic capacity, and how they engage and understand sustainability initiatives, they all share sector specific experiences and practical knowledge of contemporary art. This spread enriches the study by gaining insights into what role institutional contexts play in shaping sustainability work.

This study is not interested in assessing the individual institutions performance, but rather, how they conceptualise and make sense of sustainability and what effects this has on the organisational practices, artistic production, and employees' experiences.

1.4 Rationale and Purpose of Study

Sustainability has become an increasingly prioritised mission within contemporary art institutions, relatively little is known about how contemporary art institutions understand and organise sustainability and how these understandings shape institutional practices and artistic production. The sustainability frameworks often provide recommendations and measurable indicators, based on the assumption that the institutions are organised in a similar way, in relation to funding structures, staffing and scale of operation. But the reality reveals a spread of organisational structures and artistic focuses, in which sustainability has many different meanings and ways of being organised.

Many of the measures are compatible with productivity and efficiency oriented organisational models, which requires a strong administrative practice. This type of formalised sustainability work

requires more administration, such as manuals, reporting, surveys and data collection, while having little focus on transforming institutional culture and understanding sustainability as a multidimensional concept. This raises questions about how sustainability is conceptualised.

There is substantial research into sustainability as regards museum practices and art education, but less attention has been paid to how contemporary art institutions understand and organise sustainability. This study seeks to address this gap by examining how sustainability is conceptualised and enacted within art institutions, and how it shapes organisational practices, employees' experiences, and artistic production. The study also reflects on the link between sustainability ambitions as something entailed in growth-oriented organisational logics.

1.5 Research Question

Sustainability has in the last few years become an important objective for the contemporary art institutions to consider, but its meanings are complex. This study therefore investigates how sustainability is understood, negotiated, and enacted within art institutions, with a particular interest focus on the relationship between organisational change and practical knowledge.

Research question:

How do art institutions engage with emerging sustainability demands and frameworks, and what tensions arise between their sustainability ambitions, organisational practices, and artistic production?

Sub questions:

How are sustainability frameworks translated into organisational practices?

How are non-aligned art institutions working with sustainability

How do sustainability framework shape the concept of sustainability?

Chapter 2. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK AND LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Theoretical Framework

This chapter presents two theoretical perspectives, which are used to inform the analysis, in order to understand how contemporary art institutions understand and organise themselves around sustainability. It combines a conceptual framework for sustainability with Bornemark's (2020) perspective on situated knowledge to examine both how sustainability is conceptualised and how organisational structures influence practical implementations. These two perspectives provide a framework for analysing the relationship between institutional management, professional judgement, and everyday practices, revealing how sustainability is negotiated and enacted within contemporary art institutions.

2.2 Theoretical Framework: Sustainability

This study uses the three-pillar concept of sustainability, which encompasses environmental, social and economic factors. The modern concept of sustainability gained momentum in the 1970s, in particular with the publication of the club of Rome's Limits to Growth (Meadows et al., 1972), which introduced the idea of a 'world system that is sustainable'. The term 'sustainable development' became especially influential after the *Our Common Future* report by the World Commission on Environment and Development (1987) was released, defining sustainability as a "development that meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs". Despite now often being seen as it's own distinct field; 'sustainability science', sustainability remains an open concept with myriad interpretations and context-specific understandings. Even though it is often explained as a set of pillars, it is more commonly illustrated as a Venn diagram, and discussed as intertwined challenges of economic growth, social equity, and environmental protection. (Purvis et al., 2019).

In recent years, scholars of culture and sustainability, have argued that the three-pillar framework is too narrow, as it does not include the role of culture within sustainable development. Hawkes (2001) argues that culture should be a separate and distinct reference point in planning frameworks, not just as a subset of other pillars, and propose a fourth cultural pillar. Culture is in this context

explained as the social production and transmission of values, meaning, and purpose, and not just referring to arts and heritage. Kagan (2011), similarly argues that culture should be an essential part of sustainability, in this context defined as art forms and as sets of norms and values, as they can play an important role in moving society towards a more alternative worldview based on complexities. Kagan critiques the three pillar system, as there cannot be one 'culture of sustainability', but rather a diversity of cultures of sustainability, in this understanding, culture should not be seen as a separate pillar, it should influence and become an integral part of the other three pillars. The three pillar concept of sustainability is further complicated by Kuhlman and Farrington (2010). They argue that the change into the three pillar dimensions, from the original Brundtland Report concept (1987) concerned with tensions between a better life for mankind and the limitations of nature, has resulted in a division that obscures the problems and complicates policy making. The division between the social and economic dimensions, minimises the real contradiction between the welfare for all and environmental conservation by undermining the environmental dimension (Kuhlman and Farrington, 2010). Instead they propose to replace the social and economic dimensions of sustainability into a single dimension called well-being which needs to be balanced with another one called sustainability. They argue that, by measuring the well-being and sustainability separately, the policy formulation process would be more transparent and clear, rather than obscuring which choices that have to be made.

Despite these limitations, the three-pillar model is useful for the present study as it corresponds with how sustainability was articulated in the empirical material. As some of the institutions had not developed a sustainability strategy, the there pillar framework provided a good and mutually understandable concept to discuss around. This choice is primarily methodological, because it better reflects how sustainability was understood by most of the participants, alongside how the frameworks had conceptualised sustainability. The three-pillar model is therefore adopted as an analytical framework for examining how sustainability is understood and prioritised within the empirical material.

A central part of this study is to understand the role of sustainability frameworks in shaping the conceptualisation of sustainability. Frameworks such as the Gallery Climate Coalition and The Green Academy of Museums, develop tools and practical guides for the arts sector and turns sustainability into something that can be measured and managed. This raises questions, not only in relation to how sustainability is conceptualised, but also how it shapes forms of actions and

knowledges, influencing institutional practices. These questions are explored from Bornemark's (2020) perspective on individual judgment, the role of administration and core knowledge.

2.3 Theoretical Framework: Bornemark and situated knowledge

As an overarching lens, this study uses Bornemark's (2020) perspective on situated knowledge, to examine how questions of judgment, agency, and responsibility are acted out within art institutions in Copenhagen. Bornemark's work is primarily concerned with fields such as education and care work, but her analysis of contemporary organisational culture shows wider tendencies, also relevant for art institutions. In Horisonten finns alltid kvar: Om det bortglömda omdömet (2020), Bornemark introduces the concept of *omdöme*, which in study is estimated as *social judgment*: a situated and relational form of judgment, which is based on experience, contextual understanding, empathy, and professional intuition.

Bornemark argues that contemporary institutions often undervalue these types of judgment due to the increased influence of managerial systems which are rooted in New Public Management (NPM). These systems often prioritise standardised procedures, measurable objectives, and documentation as its managerial approach. This has resulted in a professional practice managed by manuals, evaluation systems, and data-driven guidelines, which often limits the ability of a practice informed by individual situated knowledge.

To explain this shift, Bornemark draws on Aristotle's distinction between *episteme*, *techne*, and *phronesis*. While *episteme* refers to theoretical knowledge and *techne* to productive knowledge, *phronesis* describes a type of practical wisdom which enables the ability to act ethically and appropriately within a specific context. According to Bornemark, contemporary organisations privilege *episteme;* knowledge that can be standardised and measured, but marginalises experienced based and situational forms of knowledge. In the context of art, this creates a tension, as its value and meaning are not automatically a measurable result.

In institutional contexts, increasingly managed by evaluation, standardisation, and administration, the main practices of organisations risk becoming secondary, in favour for measurable results. For art institutions, this dynamic can have similar effects, by favouring frameworks and administrational working structures, the situated knowledge and experimental aspects, often inherent in artistic practices, risk becoming limited. Bornemark's perspective provides a useful framework for understanding how institutional structures shape possibilities for action, experimentation, and critical practices.

This dynamic becomes critical in relation to how sustainability is understood and enacted within the art institutions. The practical knowledge stemming from artists or art workers, is often expressed within the empirical material as vital knowledge. Despite this, the knowledge is rarely defined and formalised as sustainability work. As sustainability has become an increasingly important priority for art institutions, often standardised frameworks or internal procedures are used to validate the institutions sustainability work. The frameworks come with badge systems, meaning that the art institutions sustainability work also becomes publicly visible, thereby legitimising them as responsible actors within sustainability.

Bornemark's perspective is therefore helpful in illuminating how institutional logics can constrain the capacity of art institutions to rethink sustainability from within.

The two theoretical perspectives provide a clear and focused structure for how to analyse the empirical material. The three-pillar framework provides a conceptual framework for analysing sustainability, from three recognisable angles. Bornemark's perspective enables an examination of how institutional structures, and professional knowledge influence how sustainability is understood and enacted in the everyday practices.

2.4 Literature Review

The literature review guides the empirical design of this study by establishing sustainability in art institutions as a complex practice, shaped by multiple and sometimes conflicting logics. Sustainability is not played out as a fixed objective, but as a flexible, context dependent concept. The reviewed literature discusses how sustainability is understood and in which ways it is made possible through organisational capacity, economic logics and managerial structures, alongside how governmental polices and sustainability frameworks are part of shaping which conceptual meanings become associated with and attached to sustainability within an art institutional context.

2.5 Economic Sustainability; drivers, constraints and effects

This section examines how economic conditions influence and shape institutional practices and sustainability work within contemporary art institutions. The literature discusses economic sustainability as a complex issue connected to constraints such as working conditions, diversity of practices and quality of artistic production. While economic stability can enable environmental sustainability work, entanglements with driving factors such as funding bodies, whose main activities are shipping and oil production, complicates this assumption. The rise of NPM and the drastic cuts in public funding are seen as main drivers for the re-organisation of public and non-profit art institutions into a metrics and goal oriented practice. The recent implementation of the Museum Law in Denmark (Kulturministeriet, 2024), by the Danish government, can be seen as an example of this, where one of the changes, is that the size of funding is dependent on the amount of visitor numbers. While this suits some institutional practices, due to scale and location, others have fallen short because of location, niche specialisations or experimental programming.

2.5.1 Economy as a driver

An art institution's economy often relies on a combination of different revenues, such as private and public funding, ticket sales and income from shops and cafés. In a Danish context, private foundations have increased their role in supporting the arts, whereas state funding has lessened. This has resulted in an increased dependence on private funding to maintain practices. In general both public and private funding are more prone to fund exhibitions and events, rather than supporting daily practices, such as maintenance, planning and research, resulting in a 'juggling' of the budget which can jeopardise artistic quality. Engqvist and Möntmann (2018), through an examination of small and medium-sized art institutions in Denmark, Norway and Sweden, argue for the importance of understanding the art world as an ecology, and not as a food chain, by recognising the different actors within an art scene. They highlight one constraint as stemming from an uneven distribution of funding amongst the different actors in the arts, and suggest a more long-term funding guarantee. Willming (2025), in his examination of degrowth perspectives within contemporary art, similarly characterises the art field as resembling a food chain, by its entanglements with a hyper-capitalist art market, driven by investment logics and tax deduction. Üstek (2024) sees, through a series of interviews and conversations with primary actors within the international art scene, a reoccurring lack of institutional development, which is seen as connected to both financial constraints and lack of intellectual thought. Üstek describes a degenerative mindset where institutions try to cut costs by producing exhibitions on a lower budget, with fewer employees and under poorer working conditions - which combined not only jeopardise the production, but also erode artistic quality.

2.5.2 Economic constraints and environmental realities

Economic sustainability, in this context, not only affects the conditions under which art institutions are working, in terms of stability, staffing and planning or how economy dictates the possibility for a diverse set of actors, it is also deeply entangled with possibilities of long-term environmental sustainability work. Willming (2025) sees an economic dependence on institutional involvement with private funding bodies, associated with oil and shipping, as directly standing in the way for any meaningful sustainability work or claims. Although climate-oriented exhibition projects have increased in recent years, Willming questions to what extent these projects can actually lead to fundamental economic and ecological changes. Üstek (2024) argues, in the light of the climate and

migration crisis, that institutionalisation stands in the way of meaningful practices, by proposing new ways of gathering around its social function, so that it mirrors values of inclusion, diversity and sustainability. The correlation between economic instability, institutional development and lack of adoption of contemporary issues, is argued by Üstek as a lack of resourcefulness to imagine new horizons for the fear of precipitating the demise of the institution.

2.5.3 Influences of managerialism

The influence of New Public Management (NPM) since the 1980's, has resulted in an increasingly prominent organisational model for the public sector (Hyndman & Lapsley, 2016). By structuring around a more hands-on managerialism, measurable results and heightened competition within both the public sector and between the public and the private sector, NPM is seen as standing in great contrast to the previous managerial model, the Progressive Public Administration, which emphasised a clear separation between the public and private sector as well as on trust in professional standards and expertise (Hood, 1995). Despite being described as an outdated model, Hyndman and Lapsley (2016) argues that its principles still influence public-sector organisations. In relation to the 2008 financial crisis, they argue that the crisis led to an intensified focus on efficiency and cost effective approaches within the UK's public sector. A similar findings were made by Engqvist and Möntmann (2018), whom saw a correlation between the drastic cuts in 2008 and the rise of NPM within culture and art in Scandinavia. They described it's effects as; "by distributing responsibility (but not power), the public sector's knowledge and proficiency have been hollowed out" (Engqvist et al., 2018). In examining austerity policies in the Museum Sector, UK, Aroles et al. (2022), found that the policies acted as a catalyst for non-profit organisations to re-structure as profit driven organisations, formalised under NPM. By diverting public services from their 'traditional, process based' goals towards, a more commercialised, outwards looking and neutral type of practice, they argue that a 'culture for sale' is at stake.

2.5.4 Effects of marketisation

Marketization effects art institutions in complex ways, as on the one hand, they are increasingly expected to organise themselves around measurable outcomes and efficiency strategies, while on the other hand, their main actives such as exhibition and art production, are characterised by

ongoing procedures, involving artists, designers, technicians and producers, whose practices and outcomes are difficult to measure and standardise. Aroles et al. (2022) argue that language is widely used to embed corporate values, norms and priorities within the public sector, by highlighting the ascription of the term 'management'. The marketisation of culture, is seen as deriving from two distinct, but entwined areas; the rise of the market and managerialism of audits. The heightened expectation of a sustainability practice amongst the art institutions combined with the increased focus on metrics, such as carbon footprints, is described by Willming (2025) as insufficient, as sustainability should also address broader environmental and ethical implications, connected to financial relationships. This perspective aligns with Demos (2016), who similarly frames contemporary art as embedded in wider networks of power and responsibility. The rise of performance metrics, in which targets and measures need to be met, has led to a shift in focal point from the artefact towards the visitor. Further more, the notion of the visitor as customer has often been mobilised to justify strategic decisions in order to follow particular strategic paths towards what is considered a successful and attractive museum.

The literature suggests that economic structures within the arts are made up of complex relationships between funding bodies, policy requirements, and managerial changes. Recent political shifts such as the drastic funding cuts in 2008 resulted in what was described as practices being 'hollowed out' and a 'culture for sale'. Both funding structures and the rise of NPM within art institutions are increasingly shaping institutional practices, highlighting a tension between measurable outputs and cultural value.

2.6 Art as an agent of change

Art is often seen as having the capacity to facilitate change, as artist and artworks has the potential to move beyond our immediately reality in proposing other ways of relating and seeing the world (Kagan, 2015). In this context, artists and art institutions are increasingly called upon to respond to the urgent social and environmental crisis, however this potential is understood and enacted in different ways amongst the institutions. The engagement with sustainability in the arts is often approached from an organisational and managerial perspective, connected to production, as exemplified by the emergence of the art specific frameworks, but sustainability can also have other forms of implementations, through collective and cross-collaborative practices. While some approaches emphasise art's ability to challenge dominant understandings and generate new forms of

ecological awareness, others question whether such practices can escape the institutional and economic structures within which art is produced and circulated.

2.6.1 Institutionalised horizons; a paralysis of the holistic

Sustainability, although being a multi-dimensional concept urgent for all, is often overlooked as a holistic, human-centred transformation, by being operationalised through climate policies or organisational working methods. The lack of focus of on what sustainability can mean for humankind as a whole, limits the ways in which it can be seen as positive, grass-roots oriented transition, representing life for all. Latour and Schultz (2022) argues that even though ecological concerns, such as climate, energy and biodiversity have become universal matters, it has not created a common horizon for collective action, instead a gathering point is through a collective anxiety and paralysis. This current state of paralysis is argued by Crary (2019), as being a result of the diverse and shifting media constructions around climate change. In the aftermath of 9/11, media helped create the idea of 'permanent war' as normal, making ongoing military interventions appear routine and thereby reducing public concerns about continued destruction. Crary (2019) argues that this process of normalisation is parallel to how media now portrays the climate crisis: not as a distant or deniable threat, but as an urgent problem that supposedly requires massive technological and often militarised solutions. This media-induced paralysis is described as increasingly making it difficult to find consensus for collective action on climate issues. Demos (2016) argues that even though art institutions have become spaces for experimentation, through research-driven and politically engaged exhibitions, these exhibitions run the risk of losing the activist and utopian ideas, once contained within highly institutionalised art venues. This perspective aligns with Fraser (2005), who states that it is difficult to position art institutions as external to the social, political and economic structures they seek to critique. Fraser argues that institutional critique itself has become institutionalised, so that critical practices can become incorporated into the very institutional structures they seek to challenge. Demos (2016) further problematises the increased presence of sustainability within the art world by arguing that the production of sustainability exhibitions, aiming to address the climate crisis, are often produced and mediated in simple ways, so that the exhibitions are sellable and attractive for visitors, running the risk of merely being a form of 'greenwashing'.

2.6.2 Cross-methods for change

To combat paralysis and inaction, Latour and Schultz (2022), suggest a system thinking model, presented as an 'ecological class', which could help redefine common grounds. By not being politically aligned, the 'ecological class' aims to abandon the traditional social and economic class categories, in favour of a new type of re-articulated class structure that centres around ecology and nature. In order to reach a new definition they suggest cross-collaborations amongst the humanities and arts, including literature, poetry, visual art and architecture, which could firmly place nature and culture as a point of belonging. A cross-dimensional practice is also suggested by Kagan (2015), who proposes a transdisciplinary (TD) process, involving artists and climate scientists. This process is not limited to sharing methods, as in interdisciplinarity or working side by side, as in multidisciplinarity, but rather as a process that moves beyond traditional boundaries of art and science. TD is seen as an extra dimension of research and action which values complexity, ambiguity, and the coexistence of multiple perspectives, by also including communities and other non-academic actors. This is referred to as 'spaces of possibilities', in which different forms of knowledge can meet through experimentation, learning and imagination. Crary (2019), likewise addresses community building as a valuable tool to work with the climate crisis. By advocating for activism that is broad, intersectional, and focused on dismantling the underlying systems of power, new pathways for collective action could emerge which would break through the paralysis fostered by the media. Crary (2019) further warns against any business-as-usual fantasies of 'renewable' or clean energy, which he sees as sustaining disastrous resource extraction in the Global South and fostering the illusion of endless economic growth.

2.6.3 Art as a transformative practice

While the implementation of sustainability policies in art institutions remain the dominant way of working with sustainability in the arts, the question is what role art plays in relation transformation and the climate crisis. What capacities does art have to mediate, encourage and inspire action and thought for a sustainable future?

Demos (2016) understands political ecology as environmental concerns connected to political, economic and historical conditions, through which the ecological crisis is produced. Contemporary art, in relation to political ecology, should therefor engage with underlying power structures and contribute with alternative forms of ecological and social organisation. Despite the rise of

sustainability themed exhibitions, Demos (2016) argues that many of them contribute to environmental degradation, due to the infrastructure of global art circulation. The challenge is therefore not simply to represent environmental issues, but to critically examine the political,

economic, and historical conditions that shape the ecological crisis. This is also reflected by Kagan (2015), who argues that artistic practices should engage with the complexity and uncertainty of climate change without reducing them to straightforward solutions. From this perspective, art has the potential to contribute to social and ecological change, particularly through practices that challenge established conventions and create spaces for experimentation and collective learning. Latour (2005), similarly sees art exhibitions as sites capable of addressing complex ecological and political issues, through their capacity to imagine other ways of organising and being. In this understanding, art exhibitions function as sites for transformative and political representation, as a form of political ontology, rather than an environmental message. Another transformative process is suggested by Janes (2010), who proposes the concept of a 'mindful museum', which entails questioning why it exists, what changes it's trying to implement and what solutions it will generate. The concept is seen as transformative as well as an essential change, in order to stay relevant and effective in addressing contemporary global challenges. Kagan (2015) brings in another dimension by discussing the role of art criticism as being a promoter of inadequate aesthetic quality criteria because art critics does not fully understand the multiple dimensions of the work they are evaluating. Kagan (2015) calls for an art criticism that is ecologically informed, politically and socially aware, and capable of engaging with the complex realities and responsibilities of art in the age of climate crisis.

In summary these perspectives discuss the ecological crisis as something connected to political imagination and community building. By different means such as; activism, transdisciplinary systems, system thinking and political ecology within aesthetics, these perspectives argue that artistic practices and art institutions can function as catalysts for change, as long as thematics and working procedures are fully recognised as environmental concerns, connected with broader social and economical injustices. The exhibition as a site is seen as providing a different temporality and space in which ecological concerns can be discussed and though about. In this sense, contemporary art offers a unique site for discussing sustainability, not by representation, but by enabling new ways of imagining a just world.

2.7 Sustainability; articulations and implementations

This section reviews a range of literature examining how sustainability is understood and enacted within art institutions. In the broader context of governmental cultural policies, sustainability has increasingly been integrated into policy frameworks, but its practical implementation remains less clearly articulated. How sustainability is implemented amongst art institutions is influenced by several factors such as funding structures, policy frameworks, access to resources and organisational culture and leadership. While there is a growing body of literature on sustainability implementation within the museum sector, less attention has been given to how sustainability is understood and enacted within non-collecting contemporary art institutions.

2.7.1. Sustainability in Cultural Policy and Institutional Practice

A recent policy brief by Kulturanalys Norden (Olin, 2025) provides an overview of how sustainability is integrated into the cultural policies of Nordic governments, focusing on political coordination, strategies, and initiatives that aim to contribute to social, economic, or environmental sustainability. In a Danish context, the government has allocated DKK 3 million to the two regional arts funds, which aims at increasing geographical distribution of cultural initiatives, as well as fostering economically sustainable cultural organisations across the country. The report finds that sustainability has become a common feature of Nordic cultural policy as well as an institutional objective, however, it also points out that the understanding of sustainability varies greatly and that there is a need for clearer implementation strategies and more concrete actions. Fehér and Ásványi (2023) analyse how sustainability is articulated in the mission statements of European contemporary art museums. Their study similarly finds that, although sustainability has become an increasing objective for museums, it is rarely developed into a holistic framework, instead, institutions tend to emphasise one of the sustainability dimensions. The International Committee for Museums and Collections of Modern Art (CIMAM, 2023) international survey-based report of sustainability within modern and contemporary art museums indicates that museums increasingly understand sustainability as a multi-dimensional concept, but that they use economic, environmental and social dimensions interchangeably. The survey also identifies several barriers to implementing sustainability practices, especially in relation to the social dimension, where weak infrastructures, low budgets, and poor planning were seen as the main obstacles. Similarly to Kulturanalys Norden's policy brief, CIMAM recognised that there is a need for clearer strategies for implementation, and points to incorporate and use the CIMAM Toolkit on Sustainable Museum

Practices. The survey highlights that sustainability should be embedded into strategy and daily practices to a greater extent, by using external certifications, by establishing clear goals, monitoring outcomes and also by involving staff, visitors and local communities in the evaluation of sustainability.

2.7.2. Formalised Sustainability and situated knowledge

As discussed above, while cultural policies are addressing sustainability as an increasingly important objective, its actual implementation remains largely unarticulated. This section explores some of the factors and constraints involved in the implementation of sustainability in an art institutional context.

Janes & Grattan (2019) elaborates on how museums can become more aligned with contemporary problems, such as the climate crisis, by moving beyond their traditional stance of being neutral and objective, stating that 'the unspoken argument is that museums cannot risk doing anything that might alienate a supporter or a donor'. This resonates with Domingues et al. (2023) study of eleven non-profit Nottingham-based Arts and Cultural Organisations (ACO), which found a correlation between environmental performances and funding structures. Apart from economy, they also detected local policies and networks, organisational culture and leadership, lack of resources and building proprietary-tenant relationships, as having an impact. The ACOs environmental work is measured by the sustainability framework Julie's Bicycle, as required by the funding bodies. Specifically used for this is Julie's Bicycle's 'Creative Green Tools', which allows the ACOs to report data on activities as well as calculate CO2 emissions. While Julie's Bicycle is helpful in providing the institutions with data, such as their carbon footprint, it does not provide guidance on how to actually reduce emissions or implement deeper sustainability changes. This according to Domingues et al. (2023) consequently echoes a global north agenda, which is fixated on material use, particularly plastic, as the main focus of environmental change. A dependance on metrics and reporting is seen by Janes & Grattan (2019), as standing in the way for meaningful change. They argue that, rather than focusing on formalised frameworks and organisational standardisations, a fostering of personal agency combined with a willingness to go beyond a traditional institutional practice enables art institutions to address critical socio-environmental issues. Rather than using a source from the outside to provide knowledge around sustainability, like a consultant or a sustainability framework, they see the art institution as fully capable of providing a situated practice themselves. Domingues et al. (2023) argues in a similar manner that ACOs funding structure,

monitored by a sustainability framework bypasses “a more holistic approach towards the environment and sustainability”.

Janes explores in ‘The Mindful Museum’ (2010), the concept of a more responsible museum that adapts more socially, environmentally, and economically to a time of social and environmental change. The article critiques the current contemporary museum model for being “based on consumption, entertainment and ancillary education”, which is seen as increasingly unsustainable. By suggesting a new direction of museum practices, Janes propose the concept of a mindful museum, which questions why it exists, what changes it’s trying to implement and what solutions it will generate. This concept is seen as transformative and as an essential change, in order to stay relevant and effective in addressing the contemporary global challenges.

The literature suggests that, although sustainability is seen as an essential priority, from which new practices and structures of working have emerged, the prevailing institutional models are questioned as inadequate for meeting global challenges, such as the climate crisis. Formalised measuring and reporting system, although helpful in seeing the environmental impact, were often seen as not offering practical suggestions and standing in the way of using employees knowledge and values.

3. METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research philosophy and design

This study is guided by a social constructivist perspective, understanding sustainability as a concept in which meanings are constructed and negotiated within social and organisational contexts. This understanding assumes that reality is not fixed but co-constructed through social interactions, language and shared meanings (Berger & Luckmann, 1966). A social constructivist perspective allows for an exploration of how cultural institutions understand and negotiate these new organisational responsibilities. This perspective allows for a nuanced and varied examination of the empirical material. Alvesson & Sköldberg (2018) emphasise the importance of examining how certain aspects of reality are socially constructed. This is particularly important for this study as sustainability is not approached as a universal concept with one meaning, but as something understood and interpreted differently within varying organisational contexts. This study does not suggest that environmental and social challenges, addressed through sustainability, are themselves constructed. Instead it takes on a social constructivist perspective by focusing on how these challenges are understood and how meaning is constructed. For example, one institution might understand sustainability as involving reduced traveling, while artistic practice can be understood as involving international collaboration. This tension is therefore not only technical, but emerges through different understandings of what sustainability can mean.

This study's focus is not to measure and compare the outcomes of sustainability work or organisational changes, but rather to understand how sustainability is understood and enacted in different institutional contexts. By using a case study approach as outlined by Yin (2009), this study investigates 'a contemporary phenomena within its real-life context, especially when the boundaries between phenomenon and context are not clearly evident'. The investigated phenomenon is how sustainability is understood and enacted, while the art institutions constitute the contexts through which the phenomenon is examined. These two dimensions can be difficult to separate as meaning and practices inform each other. The phenomenon is examined amongst seven art institutions, using interviews and sustainability frameworks as sources of evidence. While a case study design is particularly well-suited for answering the 'how' and 'why' questions by investigating complex, contemporary phenomena within its real-life context, the method has also been criticised for its

perceived lack of rigour, potential for researcher bias and a limited generalisability of findings, as the findings are analytical, rather than statistical (Yin, 2009).

There are different types of art institutions engaged in the production and exhibition-making. In this study, the term 'art institution' refers to non-profit exhibition venues, including museums, non-profit exhibition spaces and artist-driven initiatives. While the organisational structures and functions of these institutions vary, they are united by their role in exhibiting and mediating contemporary artistic practices. This definition excludes commercial galleries and other purely market-driven actors. Based on this definition, the study focuses on a selection of art institutions situated in Copenhagen and its surrounding region. These institutions have been chosen due to their engagement with contemporary art and their relevance to ongoing discussions of sustainability within the cultural sector.

3.2 Data Collection

This research uses a qualitative research design which is appropriate for exploring complex, context-dependent experiences. The empirical material is collected from three art-specific sustainability frameworks and through seven semi-structured interviews, with one representative from each institution. The interviews explored both the institutions overall engagement as well as how the individual employees made sense and conceptualised sustainability in relation to production, every day practices and artistic practices. The study has applied Rubin & Rubin's (2012) 'responsive interviewing model', in which both interviewer and the interviewee are treated as people, with feelings, opinions, and experiences. By using active listening, the interviews have been conducted sensitively so as to engage deeply with the narrative and for real-time insights to emerge (Rubin & Rubin, 2012). This aligns with a social constructivist approach, where the research is seen as a co-construction between the researcher and the participants.

The three sustainability frameworks used are the international framework, Gallery Climate Coalition (GGC), and the two Danish specific frameworks, The Green Academy of Museums (GAOM) and Handbag for Cirkulære Udstillingspraksisser ((HCU). These frameworks were selected from a broad range of frameworks due to their relevance for this study, while GGC was not applied directly by any of the institutions in the study, the main art fair in Copenhagen uses it, in

which many of the institutions participate. The two Danish frameworks were selected because they were applied by some of the institutions. The frameworks provide practical guidance on how sustainability can be measured and integrated into existing practices. The interviews and the documentary material provide insight into how both the institutions as well as the frameworks understand and conceptualise sustainability within in an art context.

3.3 Selection of participants

I have applied a purposive sampling, commonly used in a qualitative design, by selecting participants based on their relevance, rather than aiming for a full representation (Schreier, 2018). By choosing people working in different institutions and positions, the aim is to get a fuller picture of the different experience that takes place. Rather than focusing on one single institution, which would provide information into how one institution were understanding and working with sustainability, this study seeks to examine a broader range of experiences and perspectives from the contemporary art sector, in order to understand how the concept of sustainability is understood within different institutional contexts. The connection between the participants lies therefore in their experience and knowledge of how sustainability is understood and enacted within their specific institution. A purposive sampling enables the possibility to see a spread of different interpretations and attitudes towards sustainability in the arts as well as examining to what extent the sustainability frameworks have been adopted and what function they play in shaping the concept of sustainability in the arts.

This study contains a selection of interviews by employees working in larger and smaller art institutions in Copenhagen and its surroundings. The Copenhagen art scene can be understood as an ecosystem composed of a diverse set of actors with differing organisational structures, resources, and modes of operation. Within this ecosystem, artist and curators operate by engaging in different institutional settings, challenging the traditional understandings of a career ladder. An artist can exhibit in a large museum as well as a micro-institute without losing legitimacy. The same goes for free-lance curators, who are dependence on producing interesting concepts in relevant contexts could mean that a micro-institute might be a more suitable venue then a medium sized institute, for example. In this way the different actors within the art scene move around between institutional contexts. The selection of participants reflects this diversity.

Rather than focusing on a single institution, seven art institutions was selected in order to capture a broader range of practices and perspectives on sustainability.

Some institutions were affiliated to a sustainability framework, while others were not. Likewise, some of the institutions had a sustainability manager, while others had little knowledge of sustainability frameworks nor an operating sustainability strategy. This spread shows again, that the purpose of this study is not to measure or compare individual institutional accomplishments, but rather to see how sustainability is understood and enacted within different institutional contexts in the arts.

While all participants work at art institutions, the institutions differ in terms of scale, including size of organisation, physical infrastructure, and staffing. This variation allows for an examination on how sustainability is understood, internalised, and enacted under different institutional conditions. The aim is not to provide a comprehensive representation of the entire art sector, but rather to explore how sustainability is articulated and operationalised across varied contexts. This approach is informed by Bruno Latour's Actor-Network Theory (Latour, 2005), which emphasises the importance of analysing networks by following the actors and their relations.

3.4 Empirical Material

The empirical material consists of seven semi-structured interviews with one representative from each art institutions and three art-specific sustainability frameworks. The interviews provide perspectives on how sustainability is understood and enacted within different institutional contexts, while the frameworks provide insight into how sustainability is articulated and formalised within the wider art sector. These two sources of empirical material give access to different perspectives from which the research question is examined.

3.4.1 Interview participants and institutions

This list specifies what type of institution it is (Museum, Curator-driven or Artist-driven), what size it has (L, M, S and Micro), its main focus (Exhibition production, Collection, Research) and which role the participant had within their institution. The abbreviations used indicate its size, for example, in 'L 1', the L stands for Large exhibition venue. In the other cases M stands for Medium,

S stands for Small and MI stands for Micro institute. This is to make size and scale visible within the analysis.
The sizes category is in relation to how many employees the institution has; L: 100 and over, M: 15 and over, S: 8 and over, MO: 1 and over.
Within the text, the larger and medium sized institutions are referred to as 'an interviewee from Institution: X (example), as they only provide one perspective and cannot be seen to represent the entire institution. The smaller institutions and the micro-institute are referred to as institutions, as their organisation is so small that one persons view can be seen to represent the entire institution.
The table below provides an overview of the institutions and their scope.

Institution	Type	Size	Main focus	Role of participant
L 1	Museum	Large	Exhibition Production, Collection, Research	Senior Advisor, Green Transition and Fundraising
L 2	Museum	Large	Exhibition Production, Collection, Research	Head of Interpretation and Exhibitions
M 3	Museum	Medium	Public Art, Exhibition Production, Collection, Research	Senior Curator and Head of Programme
S 4	Curator-driven	Small	Exhibition Production, Research	Curator
S 5	Curator-driven	Small	Exhibition Production	Artistic Director
S 6	Artist-driven	Small	Exhibition Production	Artistic Director
MI 7	Artist-driven	Micro	Exhibition production	Artistic Director

3.4.2 Sustainability frameworks

This study includes three art-specific sustainability frameworks: Gallery Climate Coalition (GCC), The Green Academy of Museums (GAOM), and Håndbog til cirkulære udstillingspraksisser (HCU). The frameworks differs in where they are active, what focus they have and its relationship to the institutions included in the study. The GCC is an international framework, while GAOM and HCU are Danish initiatives. These specific frameworks were selected because of their relevance to the institutions studied and because they represent a varied approach to how sustainability is conceptualised.

The table below provides an overview of the frameworks and their relevance to the study.

Frameworks	Scope	Relevance to the study
Gallery Climate Coalition (GCC)	International	Focuses on reducing environmental impact for the contemporary arts sector
The Green Academy of Museums (GAOM)	Danish	Focuses on sustainability guidance for art museums
Håndbog til cirkulære udstillingspraksisser (HCU)	Danish	Focuses on circular economy approaches to exhibition practices

3.5 Researchers position and Reflexivity

The reflexivity in this study concerns both the researcher's personal relationship with the area of study as well as professional positioning from previous and ongoing work commitments within art institutions. Some art institutions examined in the study have been workplaces, while others have not. Similarly some of the interviewed were familiar, while others were not. This familiarity may have influenced the researcher process and selection of institutions, and may have created a shared understanding during the interviews, by influencing what was assumed, discussed, or left unsaid. Likewise, the researcher's own experience and understanding of sustainability may have influenced how the empirical material have been analysed. The researcher has therefore paid close attention to preconceived knowledge and assumptions by remaining critical, making sure no information has been lost and by not self-censuring during the interviews. This has been conducted by raising both positive and negative aspects from the empirical material (Alvinius et al., 2023). The interview questions were asked consistently, despite pre-conceived knowledge, to make sure no dimensions were lost. At the same time, Rubin & Rubin's (2012) 'responsive interviewing model' (Rubin & Rubin, 2012) was used, enabling the researchers contextual understanding while also being responsive to the individual experiences and perspectives.

3.6 Ethical considerations

The interviewees have been informed of the scope of this study and that the interviews were recorded. Ethical considerations such as transparency and confidentiality have been clearly communicated. Confidentiality is especially important for this study as the art scene is small and most people know each other. This is particularly important for the small actors representing themselves, so that they are comfortable in talking freely and not jeopardising their reputation or opportunities. I have followed the practices outlined by the Research Council (God forskningssed 2024, n.d.). All participants will be informed of my ongoing work experience as an artist, curator and art technician.

To ensure confidentiality and secure handling of the interview data, both audio files and transcripts were handled with a password-protected transcription service. The selected transcription service provides secure data storage and processing.

3.7 Data Analysis

The data was analysed using a thematic analysis, a method which identifies, analyses and interpret themes, allowing for a rich and detailed description of the empirical data (Braun & Clarke, 2006). The interviews were conducted in Danish and English, the Danish later translated into English and the translation was conducted without the use of software. The interviews were transcribed using the software Good Tape, a secure transcription service. The transcripts were subsequently reviewed and corrected to ensure it was accurate and that the tone was matching the empirical material, before the analytical process began. Both the translation and the transcription have been conducted with care and focus, so as not to only capture the content of the speech but also its para-linguistic features (Rubin & Rubin, 2012).

The empirical material was analysed by following Braun and Clarke's (2006) six-phase process: familiarisation with the data, generating initial codes, constructing themes, reviewing themes, defining and naming themes, and producing the final analysis. This was not implemented as a linear process, but rather as a dynamic, by moving between the different stages as the analysis developed. The process of coding was primarily inductive, meaning that the initial codes were developed from

the empirical material rather than solely being based on predetermined categories(Braun & Clarke, 2006). But as the analysis progressed, certain findings motivated a further study of literature, meaning that an abductive approach was also included. This approach involved moving between the empirical material, frameworks and literature, allowing for insights to develop throughout the process. The coding was conducted at a latent level, focusing not only on the explicit content of the data but also on underlying meanings, assumptions and ideas (Alvinius et al., 2023, Braun & Clarke, 2006).

The initial codes were compared and grouped into broader patterns, which formed the foundation for potential themes. These themes were compared against the coded extracts and the the overall dataset and further refined, so that they aligned with the meanings relevant for the research question.

The sustainability frameworks were coded and analysed using the same analytical process as the interview material, allowing for a comparison between how sustainability was articulated within the frameworks as well as seeing differences between the sources and how this understanding influenced and were translated into institutional contexts. The analysis considered both overlaps and differences between the sources, allowing the frameworks articulation of sustainability to be compared to how it was understood and enacted amongst the institutions. The final phase involved writing the analysis, in which the identified themes were interpreted in relation to the research question and relevant theory.

3.7 Methodology Reflection

The social constructivist approach allowed sustainability to be examined as something understood and negotiated differently within the chosen organisational contexts. The case study approach enabled these understandings to be explored within the real-life contexts of seven art institutions. The seven interviews should not be seen as representative of the contemporary art sector, but as a situated and analytical result. The number of interviews was due to the difficulty in finding representatives to participate, not due to the number of institutions. This difficulty may be seen as reflecting the sensitive nature around sustainability within the arts, the institutions willing to participate were either larger institutions with a sustainability practice or smaller institutions whom saw their practice as inherently socially sustainable, apart from one medium size institution whom

practiced neither of those. Despite this, the seven interviews provided a spread of perspectives from different institutional contexts, with shared patterns and themes, supporting a meaningful examination of how sustainability is understood and enacted.

The use of semi-structured interviews and art-specific sustainability frameworks provided different perspectives from which sustainability can be analysed. While the interview guide provided a solid structure for examining the research question, the semi-structured approach allowed the participants to discuss the topic based on their personal understandings. The frameworks, on the other hand provided insights into how sustainability was formalised and articulated through a wider sustainability discourse, primarily focusing on the environmental impact. These two sources did not function as opposites, but as different understandings and priorities, creating tensions between formalised sustainability goals and an everyday institutional practices. In addition, by interviewing one participant from each institution, individual perspectives have been provided, rather than a complete account of each institution.

The researcher's previous professional experience within the arts provided contextual knowledge that supported both the interviews and interpretation of the material. Nonetheless, existing knowledge and familiarity with some participants and institutions may have influenced the research process and analysis. This influence cannot be completely removed and has therefore been addressed through reflexive consideration of the researcher's position. The use of latent thematic analysis also involved interpretive choices, meaning that the themes are shaped partly by the researcher's interpretation of the material.

Chapter 4: ANALYSIS

This chapter examines how contemporary art institutions understand, negotiate, and enact sustainability in their everyday organisational practices. The analysis is structured around three sustainability frameworks developed specifically for the art sector alongside interview material from a varied range of contemporary art institutions in Copenhagen. The analysis is presented in two parts, the first encompasses the sustainability frameworks and the second, the interview material. Even though both forms of empirical material were analysed using thematic analysis, they serve different functions within the analysis. The frameworks provide an insight into how sustainability is articulated and formalised into practical guides, metrics and reporting systems, while the interviews reveal how the institutions understand and negotiate sustainability within their everyday practice, as well as showing what role the frameworks play in shaping meaning around sustainability.

The first part analyses the three art specific sustainability frameworks. Even though they all frame sustainability as something that can be measured, monitored and implemented, they differ in how they shape meanings around sustainability. As sustainability frameworks are increasingly prominent, with new local and international initiatives emerging across the arts sector, they become a dominant factor in how sustainability is conceptualised and understood. This could lead to normative expectations of participation, and simultaneously create a division between the institutions that have joined and the ones that haven't. In addition, as the frameworks focus primarily is on environmental impacts, sustainability might run the risk of loosing its other dimensions.

The second part analyses the interview material, which is organised into three themes with subsections. The first theme, 4.2 examines framework-induced sustainability, which entails an analysis of how the frameworks are understood by institutions affiliated with them, as well as analysing why some institutions remain unaffiliated. Rather than treating the frameworks as a neutral possibility for all, the interview material explores how and if they are adapted within different organisational contexts. Section 4.3 examines Knowledge-induced Sustainability through analysing medium-sized and smaller institutions engagement and understanding of sustainability. Section 4.4, Institutional Overlaps analyses how funding logics shape and influence institutional practices, with six sub-sections discussing programming, value and metrics, and organisational tempo, as well as exhibition production, public image and legitimacy and the role of art.

The analytical framework is informed by Bornemark's (2020) distinction between formalised knowledge and practical knowledge. This distinction provides a lens for understanding sustainability not only as something managed by strategies, reporting systems, and measurable indicators, but also as something enacted through situated judgement, professional experience, technical expertise, and everyday organisational practices. The frameworks are alongside Bornemark considered alongside NPM theory, informed by Hood's conceptualisation (1995). Throughout the chapter, sustainability work emerges as a constant negotiation, rather than a fixed organisational objective.

4.2 Sustainability Frameworks: Gallery Climate Coalition

Gallery Climate Coalition (GCC) is an international membership organisation working to reduce the environmental impact of the art sector. GCC does not only focus on the role of the institutions, but places the artist as an equally important actor in the work towards a sustainable art world. It's primary aim is to cut sector-wide CO_2 emissions by at least 50% by 2030, in line with the Paris Agreement, while also promoting zero-waste practices. One of GCC's initiatives is the Strategic Climate Funds (SCFs), which offers a new way to deal with carbon offsetting. Rather than 'neutralising' emissions, they encourage institutions to prioritise direct emission reductions, by allocating a percentage of their revenues to fund both internal decarbonisation efforts and the external climate initiatives (Gallery Climate Coalition, nd). The SCF initiative sees offsetting as being both insufficient and potentially misleading, and instead it wants to put focus on accountability, transparency, and a deeper institutional change.

GCC also provides practical tools such as the Carbon Calculator, the Art Fair Toolkit and the Artist Toolkit. The latter is produced in collaboration with artists and aims at supporting them in integrating sustainability into their practices by looking at production and exhibition-making as well as advocacy and activism (Gallery Climate Coalition, nd). The Artist Toolkit positions artists as key agents of change, capable of shaping public awareness and challenging dominant norms. GCC frames sustainability as both an operational responsibility and a hope for a broader both cultural and systemic transformation within the art world.

In GCC conceptualisation of sustainability, artists plays a key role as agents of change, not based on what they produce, but how they produce, turning artistic practices into a set of manageable

objectives. The role of an agent of change is often ascribed to art's capacity to imagine other futures, where change is created by meaning and content, (Kagan, 2015; Demos, 2016; Latour, 2005) rather than through materials and organisational practice. The interview material suggests that artists may engage with sustainability less as a formal organisational objective and more as an inherent part of their creative practices, as expressed by Institution MI 7 "most artists are reusing things, working with found materials and genuinely living a pretty sparse life".

This raises questions about how formalised sustainability implementations could affect artistic quality, what the benefits are of explicitly organising and measuring artistic practices, and whether such approaches risk overlooking existing forms of sustainable practice already existing within artistic production. In relation to Bornemark's perspective (2020) on social judgement, artistic practices can be understood as being based on experience, contextual understanding, empathy, and professional intuition, which stands in great contrast to a formalisation of artistic practices, as suggested by GCC's 'Artist Toolkit'.

4.2.1 Sustainability Frameworks: Håndbog til cirkulære udstillingspraksisser

Håndbog til cirkulære udstillingspraksisser, (HCU) is handbook for a circular exhibition practice made in collaboration with the Copenhagen Council and the consultancy firm In Futurum. HCU is based on existing research, interviews with relevant peers and a questionnaire amongst members of the Organisation for Danish Museums and Danish Art Institutions. The handbook consists of knowledge and tools that can be used to strengthen sustainability work in art institutions, with the use of a circular economy. A circular exhibition practice involves, in this context, everything from idea to presentation to evaluation and removal.

HCU places art and culture as a space for refection, change and experience. Art is seen as an essential element in a future where art institutions act in balance with the planet and the people who inhabit it. By minimising environmental and climate impact and helping to regenerate damaged ecosystems, Peitersen et.al (2025) emphasis that cultural institutions can help to limit climate disasters, in particular for those living in vulnerable places in the world. Even though HCU wants to limit effects of the climate crisis by 'regenerating damaged ecosystems' and by having 'a particular focus on those living in vulnerable places' (Peitersen et.al, 2025), these dimensions are not further addressed. Drawing on Demos (2016), who understands political ecology as something shaped by colonialism, capitalism, and global power relations, this statement reveals a gap between the

language of sustainability and the actual actions proposed, suggesting that the political, economic, and historical conditions remain less addressed. The use of wordings such as 'regenerating damaged ecosystems' and 'people living in vulnerable places' suggests a broader social and political ambition, not mirrored by the handbook itself, which is mainly focused on exhibition practices. The language of sustainability risks becoming more expansive than the actual actions it describes, echoing Demo's (2016) critique of how sustainability can be used as a form of greenwashing.

One barrier for art institutions to engage with sustainability, was seen as relating to art's role as an agent of change. This, in combination with the scale of operations, resulted in that many of the art institutions didn't relate their practices to the climate crisis, but saw other industries, such as shipping and oil, as the main contributors to environmental degradation. This places the role of art as an agent of change as something understood differently depending on contexts. While the GCC's Artist Tool Kit, understand the agency as relating to artist's capacity to change material practices, Latour (2005), Kagan (2015), and Demos, (2016) ascribes art's agency to its transformative potential. HCU, however, suggests that art institutions may lean on the transformative potential of art without recognising their own practices as a site for change.

Another barrier raised, was that formalised sustainability work could lead to a limitation of artistic freedom, and thereby compromising artistic quality. This tension is mirrored by institution L 1 whom both has an internally developed sustainability strategy, managed and formalised by a dedicated sustainability staff member, as well as being aligned with three sustainability frameworks. Some of the newly introduced sustainability procedures involves limited travel and transport, which often directly affects the artistic staff in relation to networking, research, transport, and shipping. This was addressed by the interviewee as; "There are some, who see it as a contrast to artistic quality… because it is perceived as opposites" and "They (artistic staff) see it as a limiting way of working". These tensions were addressed by openly discussing them, challenging traditional thinking, and asking for clear justifications when artistic priorities were cited as reasons to avoid sustainable practices. While the frameworks provide procedures and guidance, this example suggests that such tensions cannot be resolved through sustainability frameworks alone. Rather, they also need the situated institutional knowledge to implement and integrate sustainability into existing institutional structures.

The programming and mediation of the exhibitions are seen as necessary tools for a circular economic transition, in particular the themes and narratives of exhibitions. This focus should

function as a bridge towards a deeper societal change, by influencing the visitors. Willming (2025) questions to what extent climate-oriented exhibitions can actually lead to fundamental economic and ecological changes, without an engagement of how institutions are privately funded, by companies connected to un-environmental practices. Üstek (2024) argues that there is a lack of development and resourcefulness within contemporary art institutions, which stands in the way for a deeper engagement with contemporary issues such as migration and the climate crisis. She connects this status quo with the fear of jeopardising the institution's future, which in turn is connected to funding structures. The interviewee from institution M 3 remarked that contemporary art institutions have celebrated newness and a culture of novelty, with a constant production line of new exhibitions and new bodies of work. This was seen as connected to funding structures, as the interview explained *"Museums spend an enormous amount of time figuring out how to bring people in, because it* (funding) *is related to visitor numbers"*. Visitor numbers, in this context, become an important measure of institutional value, which results in an continuous cycle of exhibition production. This places the visitor as an important factor in the complexity around sustainability, both as a source of securing funding and as a driver of the continuous production of large-scale exhibitions, aiming to raise visitor numbers, media attention, and institutional visibility. The need to continuously attract audiences can therefor reinforce a culture of novelty and growth, positioning climate themed exhibitions as merely a way of communicating sustainability, without deeper engagements.

4.2.2 Sustainability Frameworks: The Green Academy of Museums

The Green Academy of Museums (GAOM), developed by the Association of Danish Museums frames sustainability as a sector-wide transition that requires coordinated organisational action across Danish museums. Through the accompanying 'Charter for green transition of Danish museums', produced in collaboration with Nordic Sustainability, the initiative seeks to operationalise sustainability by introducing shared guidelines for areas such as organisation, communication, CO_2 accounting, and professional development (Organisationen Danske Museer, n.d.). The framework does not only provide guidelines and charters, it also facilitates meetings, workshops and an online network for sustainable exhibition production, where for example exhibition systems, designed for reuse, are discussed and shared. The idea is that this will become a forum for sharing experiences and knowledges between its members.

The Green Academy of Museums, were seen as a relevant frame for organising and maintaining sustainability work, as well as a source of support, by the two museums in the interview material that are affiliated with it. This framework differs from the other two as it is rooted in the Association of Danish Museums, providing an institutional setting with staff, resources, and knowledges. Even though HCU can also be understood as institutionally rooted through its connection to Copenhagen Municipality, it is aimed 'at all those working with exhibitions at all levels - from design, to construction, to operation, to dismantling and storage' (In futurum, n.d.). Bornemark's perspective on social judgment is useful in understanding why the proximity to practices makes a differences. While the other two frameworks are addressing environmental issues, with reporting and monitoring in a similar manner, their aim is broad, trying to translate knowledge across different settings without a clear organisational sender. The Green Academy, on the other hand, uses a situated knowledge to formulate a framework, in which the knowledge stems from within a museum practice.

Within this framework, sustainability is positioned both as a response to the rapid climate change and as a professional responsibility interwoven in a museum practice. The charter emphasises that museums must contribute to a 'green and just future', framing cultural institutions as actors within broader societal transformation processes (Organisationen Danske Museer, 2023). Museums that join the charter are committing to reporting on their progress within a defined timeframe. In relation to these new work practices, the interviewee from institution L 1 remarked that they entail additional administration, but that the institution is of a size that makes it possible to have one member of staff specifically dedicated to this. While this added workload might not seen as a problem amongst the larger institutions, the smaller often don't have enough resources to perform them, as the interviewee from institution L 1 remarked "I think it can be difficult for some of the smaller institutions where you can't have a whole person for it". The interviewee continued "I would think it was great if there was some employees that some institutions could share".

Taken together, the analysis suggests that sustainability frameworks provide institutions with tools and structures for organising sustainability, through reporting and measuring. The frameworks mainly articulates sustainability as an environmental responsibility, the times social dimensions were mentioned, it was without any clear agenda of action. The tensions around artistic freedom, funding, visitor numbers, and resources indicates that sustainability, as framed by the frameworks, lacks a situated knowledge. From Bornemark's perspective a favouring of evaluation, standardisation, and administration risks limiting the situated knowledge and experimental aspects, often inherent in artistic practices. The Green Academy illustrates how situated knowledge can be

used, by formalising guidelines based on knowledge stemming from the actual practice it is trying to provide for. However, as discussed by Janes & Grattan (2019), a dependance on metrics and reporting often stands in the way for a meaningful change. They see art institutions as fully capable of providing a sustainability strategy, if the institutions are willing to go beyond traditional institutional practices.

4.3. Framework - Induced Sustainability

The sustainability frameworks presented in the previous section approach sustainability as an organisational responsibility. Across the three frameworks, environmental concerns constitute the dominant dimension of sustainability, assessed through reporting systems, documentation of practices, and measurable outcomes. The frameworks differ in how their tools and guidelines are constructed, but the overall idea is that sustainability is something that can be managed and integrated into existing organisational structures.

The interview material shows that the institutions differ considerably in relation to the integration of formalised sustainability work, which can be seen as not only relating to institutional size, but also to the organisational capacity and location. Several institutions pointed out that sustainable aspects cannot always be transferred between differing organisational contexts. The interviewee from M 3 argued that the rigidity of sustainability frameworks was difficult for art institutions located in the outskirts of a city, as the reporting and measuring on how visitors and staff arrive and leave the institution made numbers look bad. While the larger institutions generally described sustainability as an organisational responsibility, the smaller institutions often understood sustainability as an informal part of everyday practice.

Amongst the larger museums, sustainability work was seen as an institutional objective, managed through organisational structures, specialised staff positions, and strategic planning. The interviewee from L 1 described sustainability as operating simultaneously on strategic, tactical, and operational levels. Rather than being an isolated initiative, it had become “integrated into procurement procedures, environmental management, and long-term organisational planning”. Similarly, the interviewee from L 2 described sustainability as something ingrained throughout the entire exhibition process, ranging “from administration and exhibition production to procurement and the museum shop”. In this cases, sustainability was not only understood as a fixed set of rules, but as an ongoing negotiation, L 2’s interviewee explained it as “continuous conversation brings us together because it’s learning by doing. It’s not written in stone, the world is ever-changing”.

In comparing institutions of different sizes, the capacity to engage with formal frameworks differed. At L 1 who has a dedicated sustainability adviser, the interviewee acknowledged that the sustainability frameworks required more reporting and handling of data, which was referred to as resources which many of the smaller institutions don't have or cannot afford. The interviewee from S 5 explained that they had formally been part of a municipal sustainability framework, but described the participation as merely "ticking a box", and difficult to realise in reality. Limited staffing and a high production tempo meant in their case, that even simple practices, like sorting waste in the kitchen, were not prioritised. The interviewee from M 3 explained that they 10 years ago had been part of an international sustainability framework called 'the Climate War', which is no longer in use. The interviewee explained it as being ahead of its time and therefore not working well in their context, as visitors were made to feel bad and questioned why the restaurant didn't serve regular food, instead of vegetarian and environmentally friendly sourced ingredients. The institution is today unaffiliated with any formal sustainability frameworks and sustainability is recalled by the interviewee as "a recurring topic at staff meetings", yet not becoming integrated into any formal organisational structures. These examples suggests that formal sustainability practices can be difficult to integrate into an everyday practice. While it is related to resource constraints, it can also be perceived as something that is difficult to makes sense of, and therefore remains as an informal concern, rather than translated into institutional working structures.

Part of the integration of sustainability requires organisational changes. L 1, have implemented stricter travel policies, limiting air travel and requiring staff to justify why international travel is artistically important, whereas before it was up to the individual curator to decide. As the interviewee explained, "employees must demonstrate why a particular journey is artistically important before it gets approved". This practice has generated mixed feelings, with some staff perceiving them as being "a contrast to artistic quality" by limiting, for example, research trips and in-person networking.

The increased awareness and inclusion of sustainability work within art institutions were also seen as creating a tension between situated and external knowledge. The interviewee from L 1 stated that "There have been many consultancy firms coming in and making reports, which I don't always think are good", as these were seen as not being anchored in the actual practices. While the interviewee from L 2 argued that both cafe and museums shops were important factors in the institutions sustainability work, the interviewee from L 1 stated the opposite and referred to those as "easy solutions", connected to institutional image, as both museums shops and cafés are provided

by external actors. This focus was seen as standing in the way for real commitments with the actual production inherent within the institution. In this case, the L 1 interviewee understands the frameworks as guidelines, which need to be put in relation to the situated institutional knowledge. Bornemark's (2020) distinction between formalised knowledge and situated judgement offers a useful perspective for understanding this process. The frameworks provided L 1 with structures for organising sustainability work, while situated judgement enabled these structures to be interpreted in relation to the institution's actual practices and priorities. This example suggests that formal frameworks alone do not necessarily enable deeper institutional engagements, unless they are interpreted and adjust through a situated knowledge.

The interviews suggest that sustainability frameworks work well in institutions that have the capacity to work with added administrational tasks such as, documentation, measurement, and reporting. In this setting they can provide useful guidelines and tools for how to implement and maintain a sustainability practice. The interviews also reveal that the institutions that lack these resources are finding it difficult to follow and maintain. Taken together, these findings therefore suggest that formal sustainability frameworks are not neutral tools that can be implemented independently of organisational conditions. Their use is connected to institutional capacity, while their interpretation is dependent on situated knowledge.

4.4. Knowledge-Induced Sustainability

While sustainability was considered to be an important and discussed topic, most interviewees from the medium-sized and smaller institutions expressed little to no knowledge of formal sustainability frameworks and none were aligned with one. The contrast between the larger institutions alignments with sustainability frameworks and the medium-sized and smaller nonalignments should not be interpreted as a lack of interest or engagement with sustainability. Rather, many of the medium-sized and smaller institutions described sustainability as so deeply embedded in their everyday practice that it was no longer perceived as a separate organisational agenda. As explained by the interviewee from S 5; "There is no longer a need to point out to each individual how to be sustainable.. it lies as a strategy or a structure in the way people work". The interviewee at M 3 similarly explained "Just as we all think, in our households, that we must remember to buy organic products … it's really just the same way of thinking that lies in our work with art". In this

understanding, the proximity between personal life and professional practice suggests that sustainability does not necessarily need to be introduced as a separate organisational agenda, but can emerge from knowledge and values already embedded in everyday practice. This implicit understanding of sustainability was also described by the interviewee from M 3 as problematic and standing in the way of an actual organisation of sustainability work; We don't even want to talk about that (sustainability), because it's taken for granted, but in that implicitness, there is a risk that you might actually forget to talk about how we work with sustainability". This creates a tension between sustainability as an implicit practice and sustainability as a formalised organisational priority. While embedding sustainability as an everyday judgement may allow it to become a natural part of institutional practice, the way in which it has become implicit, may also make the actual organisation and development of sustainability difficult.

Among the medium-sized and smaller institutions, sustainability was to a large extent expressed through its social dimension, articulated via artistic practices, sharing of resources and situated knowledge. The interviewee from S 5 described sustainability primarily through care, support and practical help, associated with ensuring that the artists did not become overworked or financially exhausted during exhibition production. At the same time, a newly introduced open call process for the exhibition program, intended to be less stressful for the artists, had resulted in an unforeseen work load, with an added 800 applications to assess without assigning more hours for the task. A similar tension between supportive practices and unsustainable working conditions emerged at MI 7, where working with art was described as involving "a huge amount of voluntary work", simultaneously describing it as a practice of sharing economic and social resources. While this was recognised as economically and socially unsustainable it was simultaneously understood as a form of strength, rooted in innovation and resilience, which in itself was seen as a vision of sustainability, "Just being an artist or being intertwined in some kind of artistic scene is probably the most important and useful artwork that could be presented to the public as a vision of sustainability. It's how we live that is perhaps the greatest artwork". These examples illustrate that understandings of sustainability vary depending on context; practices that may be understood as unsustainable from an organisational or economic perspective can at the same time be understood as forms of resilience, collaboration, and social sustainability.

The relationship between funding structures and organisational stability are clearly present in the interview material and several interviewees expressed a wish to be able to work more sustainably, but saw lack of resources and time as an obstacle to pursue it. Medium-sized and smaller

institutions repeatedly described how everyday operations left little room for reflection, described as relating to how short funding cycles disabled strategic planning and leaving little space for developing a structured sustainability strategy. MI 7 argued that meaningful sustainability work would require time for research, consultation, and discussion, yet often the time was used for exhibition production. S 4 expressed similarly, " I could totally imagine that we could work more sustainably, let sustainability permeate everything, but that would require much more long-term planning and some more long-term concrete goals" and explained that funding was only secured one year at a time. The institution described it as having to be constantly prepared for the risk that it might cease to exist. Similarly, the interviewee from S 5 described how the institution's operation depends on a continuous cycle of funding applications and explained, "If the funding goes then we no longer exist... there is no solid ground... applications have to be sent out all the time." These institutions associated sustainability as more relating to stability and organisational continuity, than as an environmental dimension.

Many institutions described sustainability as something also embedded in informal professional practices. S 6 described having a practice storage, which provided temporary storage for artworks, until they were needed elsewhere. While the normal institutional practice is that art works are shipped directly back to the artist, collection or institution who owns them, this allowed both artists and institutions to save on transport as well as a reducing the environmental impact of shipping. They further discussed how their equipment was borrowed and lent in an informal way to other art institutions and artists in Copenhagen. As the smaller institutions often don't work around a formalised procedure, this flexibility allows sustainability to become integrated in a relational and lived reality, rather than through formalised procedures. S 4 explained that much of their material reuse, was not due to their strategy or doing, it came from one of their free-lance art technicians, who often knew where to borrow equipment or whom to pass the left-over materials to. Art institutions often employ art technicians to help install exhibitions and produce art works. The majority of art technicians are also artists themselves and have an inherent knowledge of artworks, materials, problem solving and workflows, making them an important asset for the art institutions in the production phase, resulting in an informal network of art-technicians. Mi 7 discussed how the core knowledge and practical skills of art technicians, were often underutilised by the art institutions. While the art technicians, via their knowledge knew how to work more sustainable the interviewee simultaneously argued: "Having worked as an art technician … you know what's

happening and how things could be much more efficiently done using less resources and less time, but that would be less hours that you are paid”

These findings resonate with Bornemark's (2020) distinction between formalised and practical knowledge. While the sustainability frameworks tend to emphasise measurable procedures, reporting structures and standardised solutions, the interview material demonstrates that many sustainable practices depend upon forms of knowledge that are relational, experience-based and difficult to describe and formalise. In this context, decisions around materials, production methods, and exhibition logistics can not be seen as merely technical choices but rather as expressions of practical judgement which have been developed through years of artistic and professional experience. Sustainability work does not only emerge through formalised institutional strategies, but also through the situated expertise of artists, technicians, curators, and directors.

4.5 Institutional Overlaps

Even though larger, medium-sized and smaller institutions vary considerably in relation to sustainability alignments, resources, scale and practices, there are several mutual and overlapping processes contained within the structure of art. This section starts with discussing how funding logics shape and influence institutional practices, with three sub-sections discussing programming, value and metrics, and organisational tempo. This is followed by three sections, discussing exhibition production, public image and legitimacy and the role of art. Across the institutions, sustainability was addressed and enacted alongside artistic quality, economic resources, public value and working conditions. The following section explores how these different aspects intersect and diverge.

4.5.1 Funding structures and programming

Some of the interviews described funding structures as being part of shaping artistic programming. The interviewee from S 5 explained that in order to have successful applications, they increasingly framed their projects around societal issues, so that it was seen as relevant for a broader audience, which suggests that the funding bodies sometimes indirectly influence the curatorial program. S 4 stated that the funding structure had changed in recent years, and funding from the state was referred to as seed money, as it now was private foundations that provided the substantial support.

The funding procedure had also changed, rather than sending in an application, in-person meetings were arranged to discuss the application and programming. In general this was seen as a positive change, as you saved time on writing applications that would't be funded in the first place, however S 4 simultaneously flagged that some foundations had become increasingly involved in shaping the programming prior to approving funding. Suggesting that the change in funding structure, from state to private actors, could create a new type of tension, between economic dependency and artistic freedom.

4.5.2. Funding structures and visitor numbers

The interviewee from M 3 repeatedly expressed concerns for the recent museum reform, in particularly the changes in which visitor numbers had become essential for creating a sustainable economy. M 3 as a museum for public contemporary art, makes established methods of visitor measurement difficult to apply. The museum had been told to solve the issue themselves, resulting in suggestions of QR codes and Apps, the interviewee continued " I wouldn't bother scanning some QR code or downloading an app myself, when I want to experience visual art". This example illustrates how funding mechanisms privilege certain institutional formats and how the governing funding structure are part of shaping institutional operation, leaving the institutions to spend substantial resources on how to measure visitor numbers. S 6 discussed the focus on visitor numbers as a concern related to artistic quality. The interviewee argued that some art institutions' goal was primarily to get as many people through the door as possible, stating that "There are curators who choose artists because they have been on television". The interviewee from L 1 further discussed the role of attendance in relation to a well-funded economy, by complicating the assumption that greater economic resources automatically leads to more sustainable and structured practices. As the interviewee remarked in relation to working sustainably, "*Funnily enough, too good of an economy can almost be an obstacle",* as large exhibition budgets often resulted in extensive and ambitious exhibition projects. The interviewee continued , "*There is a tradition that the curated exhibitions should be impressive. The scenography should be impressive, in general, the exhibition should be grand and beautiful … it is also the curated exhibitions we get reviewed for"* This connects sustainability work and funding structures as intertwined with public image and legitimacy. These examples show how sustainability work and funding structures are intertwined with public image and legitimacy. In this sense, economic resources can both support and constrain sustainability, depending on how they are tied to institutional legitimacy and expectations.

4.5.3. Funding structures and Organisational tempo

Several interviews also pointed towards a more fundamental critique of the organisational tempo underpinning contemporary exhibition making. This was seen as standing in contrast to a deeper engagement with sustainability. This perspective was articulated most explicitly by MI 7 where sustainability was seen less as a matter of improving efficiency than of questioning the continuous acceleration of artistic production. The interviewee described how institutions often operate through an ongoing momentum of funding applications, exhibition planning and production schedules, leaving little possibility to evaluate and reconsider existing practices. From this perspective, sustainability is not only achieved through better technologies, economic capacity or more structured management, but through reconsidering the pace and scale of production itself.

Several interviewees also questioned the art worlds' long standing attraction to novelty. Novelty is in this context referred to as a constant production of new artworks and exhibitions. The interviewee from M 3 reflected critically on how contemporary art institutions historically have encouraged ongoing productions, by expecting artists to create new works for each exhibition. As the interviewee observed, "The art world has really celebrated newness," describing how both institutions and artists were caught in a "news-hungry spiral" in which commissioning of new works became the norm. The interviewee described this outlook as tangled up with artists and institutions economic cycle, and as a rooted practice across all levels in the art world. S 4 raised a similar concern, where the interviewee suggested that institutional expectations "can push artists in a direction where they feel like they have to do something very big". Although novelty was seen as a prevailing dimension within the art world, the interviews also suggested that the increased focus on sustainability was beginning to challenge the dominant mode of production. Instead of constantly producing new works, several institutions described a growing interest in extending the life of artworks and exhibitions, by showing the same works in multiple locations and contexts. M 3 observed that institutions had become less afraid of showing works that had previously been exhibited and described it as "a slow movement towards a more sustainable way of thinking about exhibition circulation." Instead of valuing novelty above all else, artworks are increasingly understood as capable of travelling, remaining in places for longer periods, or being reinstalled in different contexts. Questions of temporality were also linked to working pace. Instead of only focusing on materials or carbon emissions, some interviewees saw sustainability as linked to slowing down the rhythms. S 4 described how working on fewer projects over longer periods created better conditions for artists and for more sustainable production processes. In this context,

sustainability is not only seen as a an act of using less resources, but also connected to a systemic change in which dominant forms of productions are questioned.

4.5.4 Exhibition production

As sustainability has become a growing consideration within exhibition production, the interview material suggests that sustainability is rarely the only criterion for selecting artist, choice of material, or scale and ambition of the production. Instead, sustainability is negotiated alongside artistic quality, curatorial ideas, and institutional visions. In this sense, sustainability becomes one consideration amongst others, which at times, creates tensions between environmental concerns, institutional cycles and artistic quality. Several institutions described how environmental considerations are part of the exhibition planning, but not a deciding factor. At L 2, although having a practice of local production of exhibition designs and art works, simultaneously stated that it is the artistic concept which is the point of departure and, in the end, dictates how it is produced. The interviewee at M 3 explained that reusing materials and how to minimise transport were part of production discussions, but similarly stated "it is not that (sustainability considerations) which dictates the finished work". Sustainability, in these cases, is negotiated alongside artist ideas and curatorial decisions, rather than functioning as Sustainability, in these cases, is negotiated alongside artistic ideas, curatorial considerations, and institutional priorities, rather than functioning as a primary factor.

Choices of material for exhibition production and designs have in recent years become an important sustainable consideration amongst most art institutions. The choices are often dictated by economy and architectural infrastructure, as some art institution are located in older buildings or in cellars with limited access. The interviewee from M 3, described sustainability in this context as a collaborative process between artists, curators, architects, engineers and art technicians, in which knowledges are shared. A recommendation from an engineer to use ground screws instead of concrete during an installation of a larger public artwork, which preserved the biomass, resulted in a more environmentally friendly solution. The example illustrates how sustainability can emerge through combining different forms of situated knowledge. S 5's head technician experimented with different building materials in an attempt to improve the practice of reusing walls in the exhibition space. The chosen wood was more sustainable, but due the exhibition concept, excessive plastering was required, which made reusing impossible, and the institution return to MDF boards. Together,

these examples shows how willingness to change and knowledge sharing can result in more sustainable work practices, but it also shows how practical knowledge, without grounded research and resources, may result in non-lasting alternatives.

Among the artist-driven institutions, exhibition production was closely connected to practical knowledge, as the boundaries between artistic, technical, curatorial, and administrative work were often less distinct. S 6 described how they worked simultaneously with curation, budgets, administration and artistic roles, and argued that the combination of these competences made for an entirely different exhibition production process. By not separating, for example, financial administration from artistic decisions, the same individuals negotiated both of these dimensions simultaneously. The interviewee positioned artistic knowledge as separate from academic knowledge, by suggesting that artists possess a specific form of practical knowledge and sensitivity in relation to exhibition production, learnt from producing exhibitions themselves. MI 7 raised another concern in relation to the prevailing exhibition model, by arguing that contemporary art institutions have been increasingly focused on “large-scale spectacle”, which were referred to as highly resource demanding and suggested that a genuinely environmental approach to exhibition production would require a questioning of these types of practices. The interviewee imagined more radical alternatives, one example being “there are no exhibitions for six months. There are only discussion groups." This perspective challenges the assumption that sustainability can simply be integrated into existing exhibition models, suggesting instead that a genuine environmental approach may require more fundamental change to institutional practices.

MI 7 extended the critique of sustainability and exhibition production more broadly. Rather than assuming that every exhibition requires ambitious material production, the interviewee questioned whether many ideas could be communicated through less resource-intensive forms. The interviewee states *“Sometimes big stuff ends up being made… everybody knows perhaps that these ideas could be communicated by a pencil drawing”* In this context, sustainability is associated with questioning the aims and scale of exhibition-making itself, rather than associating it with making existing production more sustainable. This resonates with degrowth perspectives, which challenge assumptions that value depends on continual expansion and production.

4.5.5. Public image and legitimacy

Amongst the museums, the role of legitimacy was mentioned in several different contexts, as an increasingly important priority, with public access and visitor numbers as central components. The interviewee at L 2, saw growth as natural institutional development, involving ambitions to increase visitor numbers and plans to digitise its collection for public access. The interviewee at L 1saw museums' increased focus on audience as a result of losing legitimacy, stating that "they (museums) existed for themselves and communicated knowledge that you had to be an art historian to understand". This shift in focus was a deliberate strategic move towards what was described as a "threefold, between the institution, the art work and the audience". While the interviewee saw this as a positive change, it was noted that some staff within the institution saw it as jeopardising artistic quality, and that it could be seen as entertainment. These examples suggest that sustainability engagement, on equal foot with visitor numbers and public access, can be seen as institutional growth. In this sense, sustainability is not necessarily positioned against growth, but can become another way for an institution to demonstrate development and legitimacy. Some interviews also reveal how institutional legitimacy is connected to measurable criteria. The interviewee from M 3 illustrates this in its discussion of the recent Museum Reform. As funding has become tied to visitor numbers, museums have to spend a great amount of resources on attracting audiences and showing how they are relevant for the public. The interviewee explained that reform is partly about showing that "someone actually gets something out of this," and in this way justifying public funding. But as M 3 primarily works with public art, public value cannot be fully understood by assessing visitor numbers alone.

Several of the smaller institutions expressed a different understandings of growth. Rather than seeing it as a natural development, they emphasised on experimentation and artistic freedom, and that remaining small was a deliberate choice. S 4 described that the funding bodies often paid little attention to their visitor numbers, which made it possible to develop longterm artistic relationships. Rather than thinking of the amount of visitors, they worked proactively by inviting art school and university students, and measured the quality of the audience based on conversation. The institution argued that its relatively small size enabled them to work with more obscure or difficult topics, which larger organisations weren't seen to do. In this context, legitimacy and public value was not understood through audience numbers and expansion, but rather via type of visitor and quality of conversation. S 6, located in a former bicycle basement in a new urban development, was offered the ownership of the building free of charge, when the owners could no longer commit to their

agreement. This change was seen as a transition from a loosely structured, socially bound collective to a more formalised institution, requiring more capital alongside clearer structures and roles. Growth, in this context, was understood by the interviewee as a way of pushing the boundaries by challenging traditional institutional models and present a new model, "The goal setting for us is much more based on an artistic discourse than a goal in some numbers … our results are not measurable in that way". MI 7, saw in a more explicit way sustainability as not compatible with institutional growth. When reflecting on the relationship between resources and environmental impact, the interviewee reasoned "if I had more resources, there would be more shows, more stuff would go in the trash, more people would fly," concluding that "the only way to truly reduce that is to do less of everything."

These examples show that growth, legitimacy, and public value have different meanings in different contexts, but also that its meaning is shaped by institutional expectancies and funding structures. While the three museums are under constant pressure to show their relevance, measured through visitor numbers and public engagement, the medium-sized and smaller institutions are not expected to perform the same role, leaving room for experimentation with institutional formats.

4.5.6. The role of art

Finally, on the question on how the interviewees saw the function of art in relation to its role as an agent of change, most stated that art plays a significant role in societal transformation, while simultaneously arguing against an instrumentalisation of its meaning. S 4 argued that art should not become "purpose oriented" but should retain a freedom to explore what it means to be human, while the interviewee from L 1 described art as a means to understand the world, while not being an advocate for the environment as such. S 6 expressed a related concern by arguing that artistic intentions must come before political incentives so institutional practices doesn't result in "an exhibition that can check boxes and be eco friendly and for children". MI 7, in a similar manner, argued that society needs free spaces where people can make objects "that have no obvious function or purpose other than that they wanted to make it." The interviewee from S 5 suggested that art should engage with "the world we live in" without necessarily becoming overly political. This view point was mirrored by the interviewee from L 2 who expanded this dimension by saying "Art is apolitical … art can be whatever you need in that moment". M 3 discussed the role as an agent of change from a different historical viewpoint "there was a time when art was maybe where things

happened first, or was a trailblazer for some models … and could have a knock-on effect on lots of other things in society. I think we've been overwhelmed by all sorts of digital cultures … I'm not sure that it (art) has that avant-garde phenomenon function any more". Even though art was understood as having less impact as an agent of change, art and art institutions were still able to present models of how to work, especially in relation to choice of materials.

Taken together, these viewpoints reveal that the function of art was understood quite uniformly across the institutions, despite varying types of practices. While having a transformative potential, it should not be instrumentalised for political and environmental purposes.

Chapter 5. DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSION

5.1. Overview

The purpose of this study was to investigate how art institutions in Copenhagen engaged with emerging sustainability demands and sustainability frameworks, and what tensions arise between the institutions' ambitions, practices and production. The study consisted of two elements, one encompassed an analysis of sustainability frameworks and the other encompassed an analysis of semi-structured interviews from selected art institutions. The study investigated which differences emerged between sustainability practices induced by formalised frameworks and sustainability practices induced through situated judgment, as well as how art specific logics, such as funding, exhibition production and questions around legitimacy and public image, influenced actions and work structures related to sustainability. Rather than assessing how sustainable the institutions were, the focus was placed on how they understood and enacted their practices in response to the increasing sustainability demands within the arts.

5.2 Theoretical contribution

This study was guided by Bornemark's (2020) perspective on social judgment, understood as a situated and relational form of judgment, based on experience, contextual understanding, empathy, and professional intuition. Bornemark's perspective was considered alongside NPM theory, informed by Hood's conceptualisation (1995). The study also used the three-pillar concept of sustainability as a lens to analyse how both frameworks and interviewees understood the concept of sustainability. These perspectives were used to understand how the frameworks interpreted sustainability and how they formalised guidelines and tools. While the frameworks conceptualised sustainability into available working methods, such as monitoring, measuring and reporting, they required social judgment to translate the guidelines into a meaningful practice. The frameworks furthermore mainly addressed the environmental dimension of sustainability, while the social and economic dimensions were only mentioned in passing. This positions sustainability frameworks as actively shaping what sustainability constitutes and how it can be managed within an art context, leaving the other two dimensions unspoken for. Sustainability amongst the interviewees was on the other hand related to as a multidimensional and intertwined concept, where artistic practices and exhibitions related to the social dimension, while economy, dictated by funding structure, was seen as the main keystone, enabling or disabling in which way sustainability could be enacted.

In answering the research question; *How do art institutions engage with emerging sustainability demands and frameworks, and what tensions arise between their sustainability ambitions, organisational practices, and artistic productions,* the analysis confirms that sustainability had become an integrated part of practices across the examined art institutions, but methods of integration varied in scope and scale. The integration of formal sustainability frameworks differed considerable between larger and medium-sized institutions, while larger institutions with more resources and dedicated staff turned sustainability into an explicit organisational objective, the medium-sized and smaller institutions embedded sustainability informally within everyday practices, relying on personal and professional judgement rather than formal policies. Maintaining frameworks by monitoring, measuring and reporting required extra resources, acknowledged as something lacking amongst the medium-sized or smaller institutions. Although related to resource constraints, these institutions had a more informal working structure in general, making alignments to sustainability frameworks also a mismatch between different organisational forms. While allowing a less structured integration of sustainability, the implicitness of it, was simultaneously seen as hindering explicit discussions, reflections and actual actions.

The emergence of frameworks can also be seen in relation to the rise of New Public Management within culture and art in Scandinavia (Engqvist et al., 2018). This change, constituted by heightened competition as well as the introduction of measurable results and goal-oriented practices (Hood, 1995; Hyndman et al., 2016; Aroles et al., 2022), is mirrored by the frameworks conceptualisation. In this light, the nonalignment can also be seen as an orientation towards keeping the characteristics of creativity and non-conformity associated with artistic practices alive. This also raises a broader question of whether the increasing formalisation of sustainability risks privileging what can be easily measured and reported over forms of situated knowledge that are more difficult to capture.

What emerged clearly was how funding structures were part of dictating how sustainability was understood and enacted. While resource constraints amongst the medium-sized and smaller institutions resulted in a lack of organisation and planing for sustainability, too large of an economy amongst the larger institutions could also be an obstacle. Access to larger exhibition budgets, created a tendency to produce more extensive, ambitious, and resource demanding exhibitions, resulting in an less sustainable practice. An increased pressure for public value was likewise seen as a hindrance towards meaningful practices amongst the medium-sized institutions. The funding bodies' growing focus on visitor numbers, meant that these institutions had to spend substantial resources on attracting a broader audience, resulting in high-profile exhibitions which were often materially heavy and created a paradox where financial abundance may actually undermine sustainability ambitions. The omnipresent aspect of novelty and temporality across the art world was also seen as an challenge, in which constant cycles of production of artworks and exhibitions resulted in shipping, material use, transport and temporary exhibition designs. This, taken together, presents art institutions engagement with sustainability as a complex issue with competing logics and tensions between economic survival, institutional legitimacy, and genuine sustainability ambitions. These competing logics suggests that a deeper engagement with sustainability may require a reconsideration of the pace and scale of production itself, and not just adjustments of technical and logistical factors. Challenging established ideas of how art institutions ought to operate and adapting them to contemporary challenges may allow institutions to use their situated knowledge and contextual judgement more effectively, and thereby supporting organisational change towards a more rooted sustainable practice (Janes & Grattan, 2019).

This study contributes to a development of the topic of sustainability in contemporary art by focusing on the role of formalised sustainability frameworks. Inspired by other disciplines such as philosophy, political ecology and public management, this study facilitates a development of how art institutions understand and enact sustainability. This study could lay the foreground for a larger qualitative study based on the broader dimensions of sustainability in art institutions. Building on the analysis of current sustainability practices in contemporary art institutions, future research could address the wider often under-explored dimensions of sustainability, such as the social, economic, and political aspects which extends beyond environmental concerns. These directions could help to develop a more nuanced picture of how art institutions understand sustainability and under which conditions they operate.

5.3. Limitations

While this study contributes important insights into how sustainability is understood and enacted within contemporary art institutions and how sustainability frameworks participate in meaning creation around sustainability, the findings should be understood as relevant in this site specific context. As discussed in the methodology section, my position as an artist with previous and ongoing work relations with some of the interviewees, may have influenced both the interview process and the interpretation of the material. This was not understood as something that could be eliminated and has therefore been explicitly stated. These findings should therefore be seen as a situated interpretation rather than as a generalisable representation of the art sector as a whole. The relatively small number of institutions furthermore limits the ability to make generalised assumptions and conclusions.

5.4. Conclusions

This study has examined how sustainability is understood and enacted within art institutions, while also examining the emergence of art specific sustainability frameworks and their impacts. Taken together, the findings suggest that sustainability has become an integrated part of practice, but methodology and depth of integration vary significantly between institutions, suggesting that sustainability cannot be understood as a fixed or universal concept, as its meaning is shaped by context.

Larger institutions articulate sustainability as an organisational objective, through frameworks and dedicated staff, while medium-sized and smaller institutions use informal arrangements and situated knowledge to engage with sustainability. Although formal sustainability frameworks can provide structures and guidance by integrating situated knowledge, institutions using a more loosely organised structure, may find alignments with sustainability frameworks difficult to implement, due to resource constraints, or as too formal for their practice. While knowledge induced approaches to sustainability enables flexibility and context specific arrangements, they may be so implicit that they don't result in real actions.

The discussion also highlighted how funding structures were a keystone in how sustainability was understood and enacted. While economic constraints were often affiliated as preventing deeper sustainability engagements, it was conversely noted that larger budgets can also undermine sustainability ambitions. The art world's emphasis on novelty and temporality presents ongoing sustainability challenges, where pressure to increase visitor numbers by producing high-profile exhibitions can lead to less sustainable practices, even when financial resources are available. Bornemark's (2020) perspective on situated judgement highlights the importance of forms of knowledge developed through experience and professional practice, which may remain less visible within formal organisational structures. A deeper engagement with sustainability may therefore require a greater recognition of situated knowledge and an openness to questioning established and formalised ways of organising, producing, and mediating art.

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Appendix - Interview Guide

Introduction: presentation of the scope of the study

1. Role and institutional context

- What is your professional background?
- What is your role in the institution?
- Why did you decide to work with this?
- How is your institution organised?
- How do you understand art?
- How do you see arts role in society, if it has any?

Probe: Responsibility

Relationship to exhibitions

programming

collection

2. Understanding Sustainability

- How do you understand the concept sustainability?
- Is sustainability something you work with, if so how?
- How do you see the role of the institution in relation to sustainability?
- How do you see artistic practices in relation to sustainability?
- What is art's role within sustainability?

Probe: Artistic focus,

Organisational values

3. Understanding sustainability

- If you discuss sustainability, with whom are you doing it?
- Do you feel that there is a common understanding of sustainability within your area of work?
- Have you seen any interesting sustainable initiatives in the art scene?

Probe: Environmental/Social/Economic dimensions,

Artistic sustainability,

Internal discussions

Formal vs informal definitions and Practical vs political

4. Sustainability frameworks and politics

- Are you aware of emerging sustainability frameworks?
- Have you seen any recommendation in relation to sustainability form the funding bodies?
- If you would have more funding, would you work in a more sustainable way?
- What do you think are the parameters for working sustainable?
- Do you see the different institutions as having different responsibilities?
- How do you think sustainability could be better integrated in institutional practices?

Probe: Certificates

Strategies

Sustainability goals

If any internal sustainability strategies:

- How was these initiatives introduced or developed within the institution?

Probe: Internal initiatives

Funding bodes or political pressure

Art specific programmes

5. Sustainability as practical

- How does sustainability affect the daily practice?

Probe: Traveling/Networking

Use of materials

Exhibition production logistics

- If there are any initiatives do they require more work?

Probe: Reporting

Collection of Data

Guidelines

Internal coordination

6. Bæredygtighed og kunstnerisk produktion (8 minutter)

- Does sustainable considerations affect curatorial or artistic decisions?

Probe: *Exhibition design*

Choice of artists / scale of production

- Have you experienced any tensions between sustainability ambitions and artistic or institutional interests?

Probe: *Artistic freedom*

Internal collaborations

Expectations of production

7. Organisatorisk forandring og medarbejderoplevelse

- From your perspective, how do you understand sustainability initiatives?
- Are they meaningful or are they adjustment within existing strictures?

Probe: *Cultural change*

Symbolic vs. Structural change

Collaboration from staff

8. Critical reflection and future

- What is a real sustainable institution according to you?

Probe: *Organisational structures*

Artistic practices

Production scale

Working conditions

Optional Closing Question

- Is there anything around sustainability within art institutions that you feel are overlooked or misunderstood?